

Behavioral Interview Guide



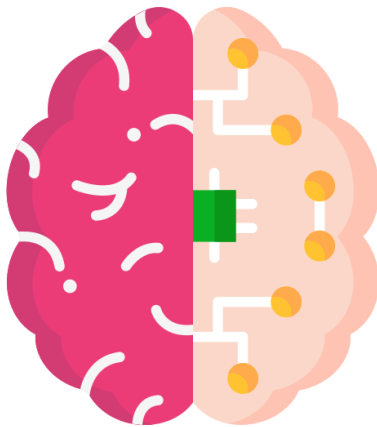
Hey there, welcome to my guide! Glad you made it.
I will try not to bore you to death, so hold your
socks, remain open-minded and enjoy the reading
:)

Behavioral questions, **what does it even mean?** **Where should you start?**
How to cover a variety of questions without wanting to throw your rubber
🦆 out the window?

Genuity

While you should remain genuine during the interview process, it's not an excuse not to prepare.
I wouldn't have made it through my Amazon and Google interviews back in 2017 if that weren't
for the steps outlined in this guide.

Don't Be Gassy Tim



Preparing for the behavioral interview feels intimidating and
overwhelming.

*Tim is interviewing for FAANG. Tim doesn't know what to expect.
He feels unprepared. During his interview, he gets sweaty, gassy,
and uncomfortable. Tim breathes loudly, his stomach hurts, and
he wishes he had prepared more instead of binge-watching on
youtube and watching duck videos. Tim gives generic
unstructured answers. He gets confused, so the interviewer.*

We will go over simple steps to not become Gassy Tim in your next interview.

It's all BS!



"I'd rather rub hot spices in my eyes than answer behavioral questions."

A Googler I recently interviewed took offense at the Behavioral Questions I asked. Arguing that it wasn't how he had interviewed in the past. That it was too long and left too little time for the coding question itself.

It doesn't matter how great you are at coding dude. It's all BS!

By BS, I mean **B**ehaviors before **S**kills, what else did you expect? I have seen excellent coders solving LeetCode hard problems like clockwork fail because of behavioral interviews.

You need to be able to showcase your experiences. Your past performance is a good indicator of your future performance.

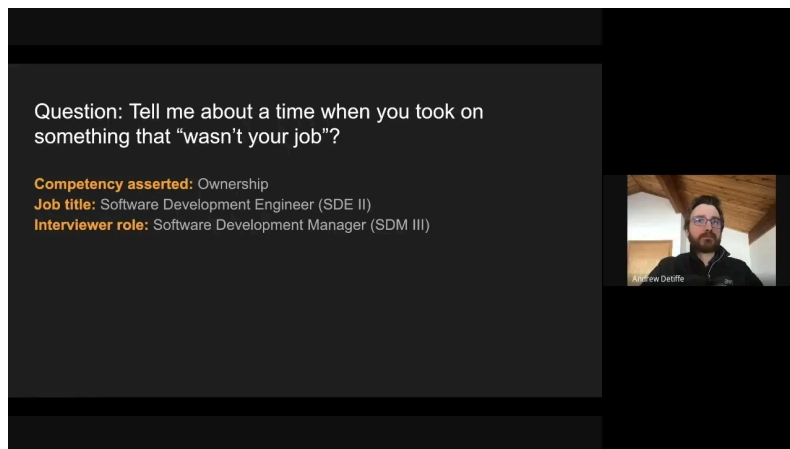
Real-World Questions And Answers

One of the best ways to learn is by seeing examples and engaging. For this section, I recommend you attempt to answer the below behavioral questions and then watch each video. I have many more of those!

Update: I have just released 15 video recordings of Amazon & Google Behavioral Interviews [here](#) on YouTube. Those videos are issued from my course so that you know what to expect in your upcoming interviews.

Interview Example 1

[Watch video.](#)



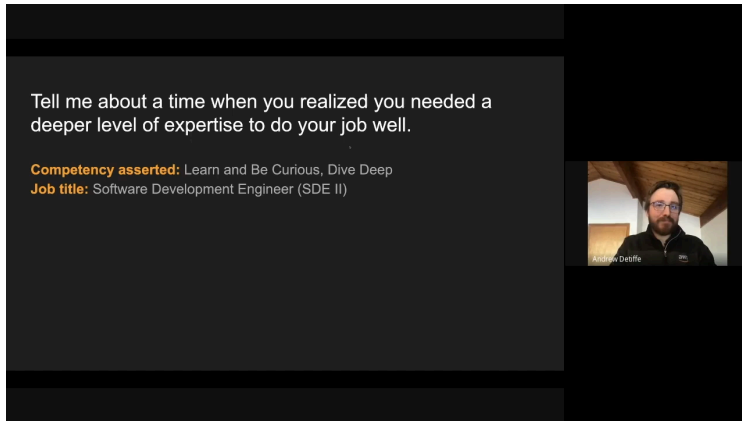
Question: Tell me about a time when you took on something that "wasn't your job"?

Competency asserted: Ownership
Job title: Software Development Engineer (SDE II)
Interviewer role: Software Development Manager (SDM III)

Alfred Dettfe

Interview Example 2

[Watch video.](#)



Tell me about a time when you realized you needed a deeper level of expertise to do your job well.

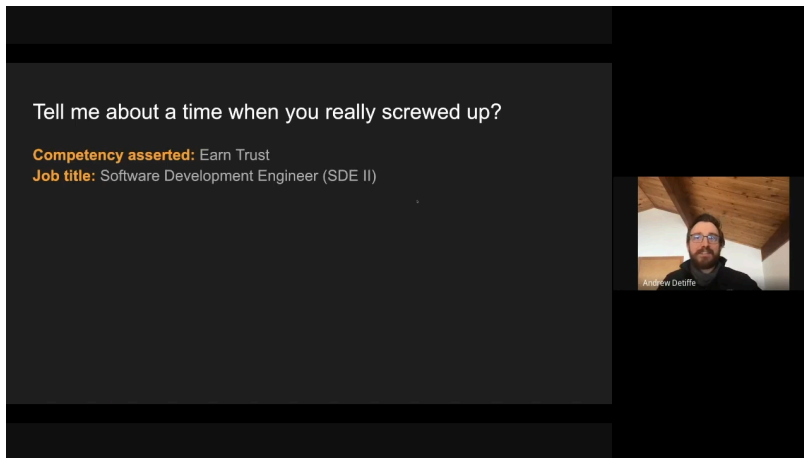
Competency asserted: Learn and Be Curious, Dive Deep
Job title: Software Development Engineer (SDE II)

Andrew Deitle

A video player interface with a dark background. On the left, a text box contains an interview question and the candidate's response. On the right, a small video window shows the candidate, Andrew Deitle, a man with a beard and glasses, wearing a dark jacket, in a room with a wooden ceiling.

Interview 3

[Watch video.](#)



Tell me about a time when you really screwed up?

Competency asserted: Earn Trust
Job title: Software Development Engineer (SDE II)

Andrew Deitle

A video player interface with a dark background. On the left, a text box contains an interview question and the candidate's response. On the right, a small video window shows the candidate, Andrew Deitle, a man with a beard and glasses, wearing a dark jacket, in a room with a wooden ceiling.

Interview 4

[Watch video](#)

Question: What is your biggest accomplishment in your career?

Competency asserted: Deliver Results
Job title: Software Development Engineer (SDE II)
Interviewer role: Software Development Manager, Bar Raisers



Andrew Dettie

Step 0: Tiger Warm-Up



For the warm-up, start wiggling your fingers and Roooar is if you were a tiger. Then, when you have reached maximal flexibility, let's get those fingers typing. Make a copy of [the worksheet](#) and fill out Part 1.

Step 1: STAR

While I wish this section was about astronomy, it is not. The STAR approach helps you to structure your behavioral answers.

STAR stands for Situation Task Action Results, it helps give:

- the context (**S**ituation)
- and identify what was asked from you (**T**ask)
- what you end up doing (**A**ction)
- and what the outcome was (**R**esult).

People also call it PSMO (Problem, Solution, Method, Outcome) or POOP (I made up that last acronym). Yes, I talk a lot about poop (maybe because I have 2 young kids).

For an example of a STAR answer: watch [this video](#) I made with love.

❤️Tip!

A structured answer allows for easy follow-ups. Some interviewers may stop you and ask you clarifying questions, while others will let you mumble while they think about the next episode of The Mandalorian (who can spell this word anyways).

Step 2: Story Bank

DO NOT STUDY ANSWERS TO LIST OF QUESTIONS (My 🦆 was on caps lock, sorry).

See, if you go on LeetCode, Youtube, etc it's full of well-intentioned people posting "100 behavioral interview questions". There is no way I could remember all these questions or individual answers. I can barely remember what I ate yesterday for lunch.

Instead...

Prepare 15-20 good stories in total, across multiple themes. That way, you will be able to reuse some stories for multiple questions. We will also go over The Zoom In/Out technique you can use to "make it look like you are not reusing stories".

Prepare stories for the below themes:

- An interesting **technical problem** you solved.
- An interpersonal **conflict** you overcame.
- A time when you demonstrated **leadership** or **ownership**.
- A situation where you should have **done differently** in a past project.
- Do you **fix things** that aren't quite right, even if you don't have to?
- A time you acted on a piece of **feedback** you received.
- Something you **learned** recently

Story Bank

You can organize everything in rows and columns. The nugget is just a very brief description of the story.

#	Project	Nugget	S	T	A	R
1						

- I had way over 15 stories which made it hard to remember.
 - Having a nugget column helped a lot.
- No fancy tools were required, it was a simple One Note ge.

by Mocki.co

Step 3: Identify Where You Lack Experience

Video: [link](#)

The goal here is to identify categories where you lack experience or don't have any answers.

Method 1: Research Examples of Questions Online

How do you do this? You can go the hard way:

- Find examples of questions online
- List the questions you can't answer.
- Group those questions by themes.
- Each theme then becomes a gap you need to address.

Or...

Method 2: Use Company Values

Company values are common traits found amongst employees of a specific company.

Research the values of the companies you are targeting.

Or use proven, broad competencies as laid out by Amazon called the Amazon Leadership Principles. Amazon has the most comprehensive list, may as well use it. It doesn't matter if you don't want to interview for Amazon. It's just a template.

Exercise

Match each Amazon Leadership Principle to 1 or more stories from your Story Bank.

Example:

- [Yes] Customer Obsession
- [No] Dive Deep with metrics
- etc.

Step 4: List Your Closest Experiences

Secret: Behavioral questions don't all have to be about work! I touch on this in the same [video](#).

Use the list from Step 3 and identify any experiences that could be relevant;

- **Student jobs**
 - e.g: that student job at Dominos Pizza that allowed you to eat pizzas for free all summer.
- **School projects**
 - e.g: that group project where you left poor little Tim to work alone the entire weekend because you had mixed up the coworking dates
- **Volunteering**
 - e.g: that organization you were involved in as a highly trained fireflies rescuers.
- **Side projects**
 - e.g: treasure hunt
- **Past jobs**
 - e.g: your previous gig as former President of the United States (for rooftop builders)

Examples:

- Feedback: a candidate once told me about feedback he received when he was at the army!
- Learning: Back in 2017, I ran with "How I fixed my dishwasher" for my Amazon interview
- Ownership: I created an app for fireflies rescuers, people can log rescues

Step 5: Improve Your Experiences

Sometimes it's about rephrasing and seeing things from a different perspective.

Change: I was asked to...

To: I drove this change based on...

For example:

Tell me about a time you improved the life of your customers. Why was it important? How did you do it?

Before: "I fixed bugs for the past 3 years, I was given bugs by my manager and I was fixing them like clockwork."

After: "My primary focus at company X was operations and quality. I have quickly identified areas of improvement in our applications. I didn't have direct access to customers so I went on our forums and searched for customer issues for our products. I even monitored Twitter! I vouched for bugs to leadership and I was trying to gather as much customer feedback as possible. I became the de facto owner for our customer bugs backlog."

(I did the Twitter thing back at Amazon)

Step 6: Role Play

Partice with a peer, a friend, or your +1. If you don't have anyone around but your rubber duck (we all have been there), you can record yourself and then review your answers on your own.

You can also use a community-driven mock interview platform like Pramp! More on this [here](#).

3 Things Interviewers Don't Want You To Know

1#: Get Out of Jail Free card

It's ok to not have answers to all behavioral questions asked during an interview. Interviewers have backup questions. Briefly explain why you don't have an answer. Don't waste time.

If you have something close enough, say it to the interviewer.

"Can't think of a great answer, I have something close I think", STAR it.

2# Unconscious Biases

Biases lead to false positives (or negatives). Unconsciously, interviewers can try to find reasons to decline a candidate or favor a candidate.

It doesn't have to be "big" controversial and political characteristics, it can be as simple as seeing a can of beer next to a candidate during a remote interview or judging someone based on how the person is dressed. For instance, I sometimes look like a skateboarder because I wear my cap backward. I noticed that people behave differently when I do this, they categorize me one way or another as a couch potato with no ambition.

3# Cheat sheet

You should confirm with your recruiter, but companies like Amazon allow candidates to have a cheat sheet or notes. I strongly discourage this though as I have seen candidates getting confused about this.

8 Tips To Not Fail Your Interview

Video: [link](#)

1. Choose **recent stories** - two years old or less. Resist the temptation to reuse those great 10-year-old stories.
2. **"Meaty stories"** with lots of details for easy follow-ups (even for vegans).
3. Avoid reusing the same story **too many times** (debrief, etc)
 - Unless you use the Zoom In / Out Technic - that is you focus on a specific bit of a story without giving the full context.
4. Map your stories to **company values** (culture fit).
5. Include a **mix** of successes, failures, and lessons learned.
6. Team leads, **don't inflate** your role. Your team's success reflects well on you.
7. **Don't assume** interviews know everything. If you talk about that weird C library you used - the interviewer may not know what that is or what it does.
 - Same if you use jargon or terminology from previous employers.
8. Pay attention to your interviewer's **body language**
 - let your interviewer speak, help and refocus the conversation.

Checklist

I recommend going over this checklist before your behavioral interview.

- ☐ I am familiar with the STAR approach
- ☐ I have a story bank of at least 10 questions
- ☐ I have stories about
 - ☐ Customers
 - ☐ Ownership
 - ☐ Conflicts
 - ☐ Feedback
 - ☐ Troubleshooting
 - ☐ Learning something new
 - ☐ Something you improved
 - ☐ Sharing knowledge
 - ☐ A mistake you learned from
- ☐ I have been rehearsing stories with a friend or peer



Questions?

I hope you found this guide helpful. Reach out to me at andrew@mocki.co if you have questions or if you would like me to explore a specific concept.

Good luck with your upcoming interviews, you are on the right track, keep up the hard work!